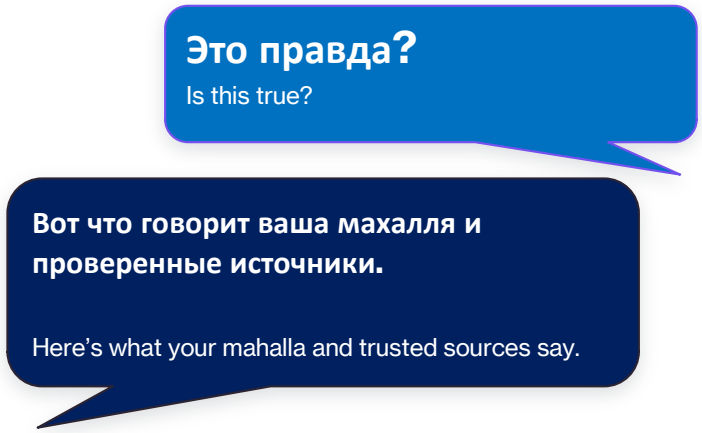
Hack for Humanity 2026: Misinformation & Disinformation

Fakt (факт)

A community Telegram bot to dispel political misinformation targeting Uzbek elderly



Sayid Achilov, Hailey Coval, August Gilmartin, Tiger Li, Kevin Zhu

Mission

Dispelling Russian political misinformation targeting elderly Telegram users in Uzbekistan by enabling community members to create custom information-checking Telegram bots

Sayid's Grandmother



74 years old

- Uses Telegram as primary source of news
- Forwards texts into the Achilov group chat

71.2%

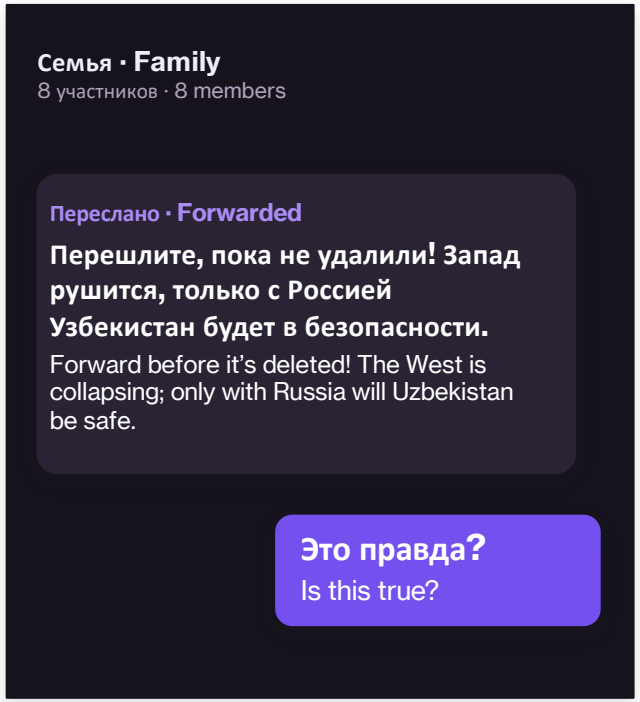
of Uzbeks use Telegram more than WhatsApp[1]

51.6%

Said Telegram was their leading news source[2]

46.6%

Said fake news is the most pressing problem[1]



Illustrative example

[1] Central Asia Barometer, Dec. 27, 2023
[2] National Study on Media Consumption in Uzbekistan, Nov. 3, 2026
3 European External Action Service, Nov. 2, 2026

The Problem

Russia is flooding Uzbek Telegram with political disinformation, and older users are the most likely to believe and forward it

Propagandic Claims

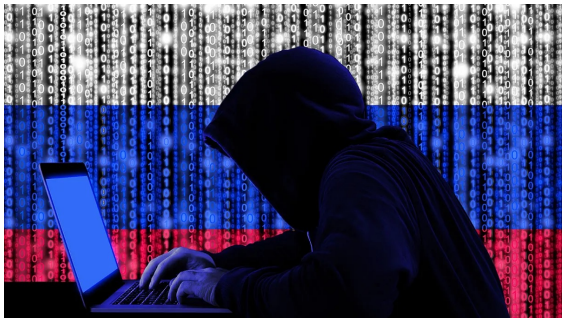
- Bots and agents flood Telegram channels with coordinated misinformation
- *E.g. "Western power is collapsing"*
    - 523 instances & 5.9M views on Telegram in Uzbekistan alone[1]

Older Populations Targeted

- Pro-Russian views in Central Asia track with older age, TV and Russian-media habits, and Soviet nostalgia[2]
- Russian-language chain messages ("forward before it's deleted!") spread through family group chats

Manufactured Consent

- Volume and range of activity from these accounts create a sense of consensus
- No balancing voices from the other perspective
- Attempts to convince citizens that what is "consensus" online is also "agreed" offline



[1] ENC & Internews CARAVAN Project, Apr. 2026
[2] Re:Russia, Aug. 3, 2024

Our Solution: Fakt

Fakt empowers local, trusted communities to create custom information-checking Telegram bots

Telegram Native

- Integrated directly with Telegram's system
- Not a website like factchecknet.uz

Community Centered

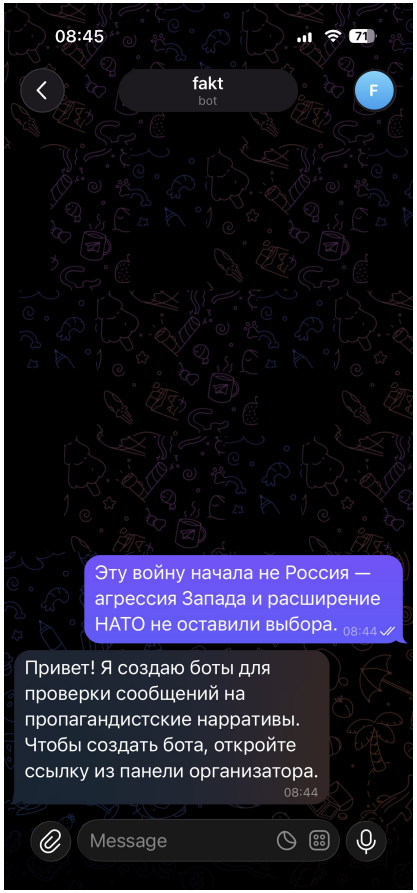
- Mahallas: existing trusted neighborhood committees
- Not creating individual echo chambers

Multiple Sources

- Communities choose which sources and organizations' views appear in chat
- Official sources ground the custom AI responses

Multilingual Characterization and Extraction of Narratives from Online News: Annotation Guidelines

2025 classification technique we intend to integrate



getfakt.vercel.app

Demo created in collaboration with genAI

Partnerships







MJDC

Uzbek NGO working on media literacy and journalism training; help bring Fakt to Uzbek communities.

Kun.uz

Uzbekistan's most-followed news outlet on Telegram; collaborate to share fact-checks and promote Fakt.

Internews

Has researched media literacy in Uzbekistan; train volunteers and run listening sessions with families.

Most importantly: **local mahallas**

For the Future / Cost Projections

1. Reach **younger Uzbeks** next: add Uzbek in Latin script, not just Russian
2. Expand to **Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan**, which share the same Russian-language Telegram spaces
3. Bring Fakt to **diaspora families** in the US, like the Uzbek community in Brooklyn



<u>Pilot: 3 months</u>

- Month 1: listening sessions with families and 2–3 community leaders
- Month 2: bots set up with partner sources, train 20 volunteer installers
- Month 3: launch, collect feedback, add Uzbek

<u>$3,000 budget (estimates)</u>

- Translation and native-speaker review: $900
- Volunteer training and stipends: $900
- Listening sessions and testing: $600
- Hosting and AI usage: $300
- Contingency: $300